

SHOCK TREATMENT

While European teams dominated proceedings, there were some **upsets** too.

Joan Mathew Jacob
joan.mathew@thehindu.co.in

The Club World Cup's rollout in a new format in the United States has certainly captured the American glitz and glamour. From individual player walkouts to Juventus players and staff visiting President Donald Trump in the Oval Office hours before a match, the tournament has been anything but dull. The games themselves have been engrossing, with goals aplenty — Bayern Munich set the tone in the second game by putting a record 10 past New Zealand club Auckland City. The 32-team competition has also allowed lower-ranked sides from around the globe to showcase their grit against the best in the world. Off the pitch, 'soccer' fans have turned up in thousands to meet their favourite superstars in the flesh. At the same time, the debate around player welfare has continued to escalate, driven by match timings and erratic weather. On one hand, players have been forced to play under a scorching afternoon sun; elsewhere,

up to six matches were delayed due to thunderstorms and severe conditions. Despite the criticism from players and managers being loud and persistent, the one billion dollar prize pool and the subsequent millions in participation money have made it nearly impossible for teams to ignore the tournament.

Brazilian flair

Some of the most eye-catching spectacles of this revamped edition have been the performances of the Brazilian clubs. In the group stage, European giants such as Chelsea and Paris Saint-Germain were slayed by Flamengo and Botafogo respectively, while Fluminense and Palmeiras also held their own against superior opposition. All four Brazilian teams progressed to the knockout phase, while its neighbour Argentina was not as fortunate. Both of its representatives — Boca Juniors and River Plate — buckled under the pressure, with the former even being held to a 1-1 draw by Auckland, a side ranked 4,586 places below it. However, the Brazilian clubs' fortunes began to fade as the round of 16 commenced, with Botafogo losing to rivals Palmeiras in a heated contest,

courtesy of an extra-time winner from Paulinho. The following day, Flamengo met its match against Bundesliga champion Bayern Munich, losing 4-2.

Shock exits

Defending champion Manchester City was the only team to maintain a perfect record in the group stage. Meanwhile, City's compatriot Chelsea bounced back from its defeat against Flamengo to progress from the group. It then ruthlessly dispatched Benfica 4-1 in their round of 16 clash, which was suspended in the 85th minute for nearly two hours due to a storm warning. Meanwhile, both Real Madrid and Borussia Dortmund overcame lacklustre starts to finish top of their respective groups, partly thanks to the performances of the Bellingham brothers — Jude in Madrid, and Jobe, who eased into his first campaign with the Black and Yellow. Following its loss against Botafogo, Atlético Madrid was eliminated from the competition after finishing third in a three-way tie in its group. Other European exits included Porto and RB Salzburg.

One of the most debated topics ahead of the CWC was the inclusion of Lionel Messi's Inter Miami as a host nation representative, rather than qualifying through the ranking system like the rest. However, the Major League Soccer side brushed off the criticism and embraced the opportunity. It earned draws against Al Ahly and Palmeiras, while a vintage Messi free-kick helped the club record a landmark 2-1 win over Porto. This also meant that the 38-year-old Argentine maintained his streak of never exiting in the group stage of a knockout tournament — at both club and international level.

That said, the disparity in quality between MLS and elite European sides became apparent when Miami faced UEFA Champions League winner PSG in the round of 16 (**above**). Four first-half goals, including a brace from Joao Neves, settled the contest early, putting the Parisians one step closer to adding another trophy to their cabinet after a historic treble-winning season.

(All results updated as of June 29)